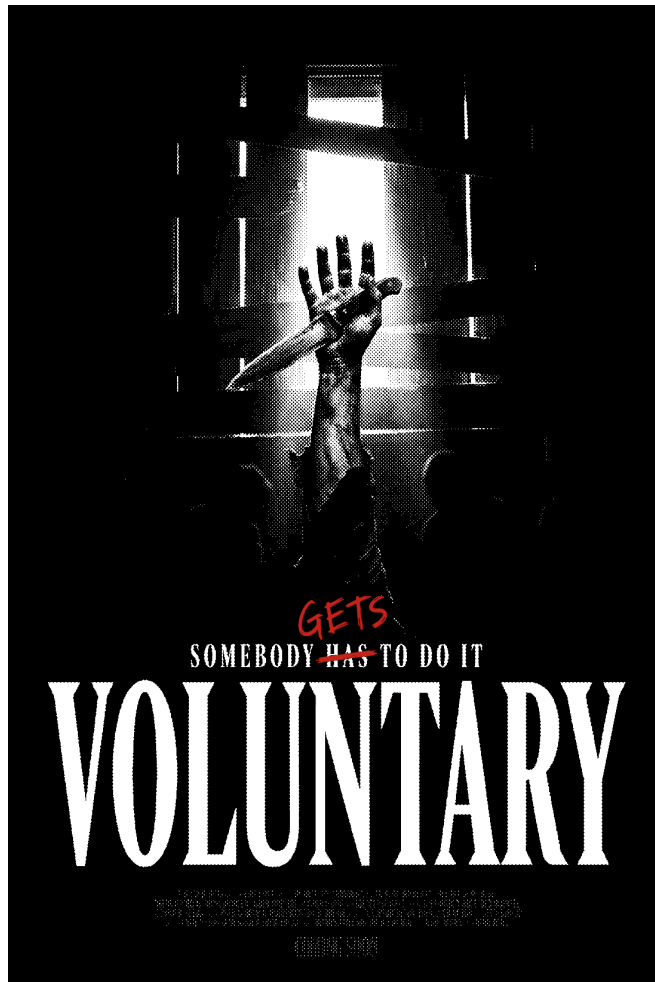




VOLUNTARY

Punchy, tense comedy. Approx. 4 min.

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INT. BOARDED-UP LIVING ROOM - NIGHT

Windows blocked with scrap lumber. A camping lantern doing all the work. CLOSE ON A MOUTH. CRISTIAN's. Two teeth gone, the gap dark and real. WIDEN. He sits on the coffee table, shirt off, bloody. NYLA works a gash in his shoulder with a rag and a bowl of water gone pink. Quiet. Tender. They have done this before. CATHY stands at the boards, listening to the room rather than looking at it.

NYLA

Hold still.

CRISTIAN

I am still.

CATHY

Shh.

Nobody moves. The front door BANGS open. DEAN falls through it, wild, clutching his left forearm. Blood on the sleeve.

DEAN

I got bit. I got bit. Tie me up.

TIE ME UP.

TERRY comes in from the hallway. Takes in the room. Calm. He looks at the arm. At DEAN. Something crosses his face and leaves.

TERRY

Okay.

They sit him in a hard chair, rope around his chest, wrists behind.

DEAN (CONT'D)

Tighter.

CRISTIAN

(not adjusting anything)

Okay.

They step back.

DEAN (CONT'D)

You have to kill me. Before I
turn. Or I take all of you with
me.

Silence. It's true and everyone knows it's true.

TERRY

Okay. I'll do it.

NYLA puts a hand on his arm.

NYLA

Terry --

TERRY

It has to be me.

He is looking straight into DEAN when he says it.

NYLA

...Okay. Thank you. But why?

TERRY

Because I actually hate him.

CATHY

Wait, WHAT?

DEAN

Just do it, I don't care, just --

(stopping)

What do you mean you hate me?

TERRY

(reasonable)

Don't act like you don't know. I'm going to enjoy this. That's why it has to be me.

NYLA

That is a horrible thing to say to him right now.

TERRY

Would you rather get killed by somebody who's going to enjoy it? Or by a friend who's shaking, who's crying, who's never done it, and it takes four tries?

Silence. It is, unfortunately, a good point.

CRISTIAN

He's not wrong.

(beat)

Random question. Can I have his teeth?

CATHY

What the f---?

TERRY takes out the knife and wipes it down the leg of his jeans, which makes it worse, not better. Then he crosses and goes straight for the throat, no hesitation, a foot away before anybody says anything.

DEAN (CONT'D)

Wait wait wait. Is this weird? Guys.

CATHY

Yeah, it's really weird.

TERRY

I know.

But it's not weird for me.

DEAN
(gaining momentum)
Oh my God. Okay, just do it. I
love you guys. More than my
family. I mean that. I'd be
nothing without you, I'd be
NOTHING --

His voice catches and turns into a low wet rattle. He keeps finding more. Every few words he checks the room to see whether anybody is going to get up. Nobody gets up. TERRY rolls his eyes and raises the knife to DEAN's neck.

And DEAN, lost in it, WORKS HIS LEFT ARM LOOSE without noticing and throws it up in a gesture. The forearm passes right in front of TERRY's face. TERRY stops. The blood on it has smeared. Dragged sideways. Too much of it, and wrong, and wipeable.

He catches the wrist, turns it into the light, then slowly lifts DEAN's own arm up to DEAN's own mouth. The teeth line up. DEAN's eyes open.

TERRY
No.

TERRY holds the arm there so the whole room can see the marks sit into the gaps exactly.

TERRY
(quiet)
You were really gonna let me do
it.

DEAN detonates.

DEAN
I KNEW IT! I KNEW you'd do it!

TERRY
(arms out, vindicated)
Are you guys SEEING this? THIS is
why I should kill him. It is
ALWAYS this.

CATHY
You were going to let him put a
knife in your neck to WIN AN
ARGUMENT?

DEAN
To prove a point.

CRISTIAN
(quietly, to nobody)
Sooo no teeth then, huh?

NYLA
Why are you all like this.

Everyone is yelling. Nobody is the hero. Outside, something drags past the boarded window. Nobody notices.